

Characters & Setting In Poems ★

How poems portray people and places differently from prose — copy every box below

✎ WHY CHARACTERS IN POEMS WORK DIFFERENTLY FROM STORIES

In a story, you might get several paragraphs directly describing a character's appearance, history, and personality. Poems almost never have room for this — they are short and economical. Instead, poems reveal character through **small, carefully chosen details**: one gesture, one object, one line of speech, one physical detail that stands in for a whole personality.

PROSE CHARACTERISATION	POETIC CHARACTERISATION
Long physical description	One precise, symbolic detail (e.g. "hands like rope" tells you about a whole lifetime of work)
Narrator directly explains a character's feelings	A single action or gesture implies the feeling ("she folded the letter twice, then once more")
Dialogue develops over many exchanges	Often only one or two lines of speech are given — every word matters
Character arc shown across chapters	Character change often shown through contrast between the poem's first and last stanza only

Golden rule to copy down: in a poem, ANY specific physical or behavioural detail (a gesture, an object, a repeated action) is almost never random — it is doing the work an entire paragraph of description would do in a story. Always ask "what does this detail tell me about the character that isn't stated directly?"

✎ THE SPEAKER VS. THE POET VS. A CHARACTER — DON'T CONFUSE THEM

THE POET	The real person who wrote the poem (rarely relevant to answer — avoid writing "the poet feels..." unless the poem is clearly autobiographical).
THE SPEAKER / PERSONA	The "voice" telling the poem — this is who you should usually refer to in your answers ("the speaker feels...", not "the poet feels...").
A CHARACTER WITHIN THE POEM	Someone the speaker describes or talks about, who is not the speaker themselves (e.g. a poem about the speaker watching their mother).

Exam tip: examiners reward students who correctly distinguish "the speaker" from "a character" from "the poet" — using the wrong one is a common accuracy slip that costs marks even when the idea is right.

STRUCTURE 1 OF 6

Use this whenever a character is only given one or two details

1. Identify the ONE specific detail given (an object, a gesture, a physical feature, a line of speech).
2. Ask: what does this detail suggest about their personality, history, or emotional state?
3. Ask: is this detail repeated or returned to later in the poem? If so, it's especially significant.
4. Explain what the detail reveals that isn't directly stated.

STRUCTURE 2 OF 6

Poems reveal character through these 5 indirect methods — check all 5

1. **Action** — what does the character DO, and what does that action suggest?
2. **Speech** — what do their exact words (if any are quoted) reveal, including what they DON'T say?
3. **Object** — is the character linked to a specific object that represents them?
4. **Others' reactions** — how do other people in the poem respond to this character?
5. **The speaker's own tone** — does the way the speaker describes the character reveal the speaker's own feelings about them (admiration, resentment, love, distance)?

SETTING IN POEMS — THE FULL NOTES

Poems rarely describe a whole setting in full detail the way a novel might. Instead, poets choose a small number of loaded details that do double duty — describing the place AND reflecting the mood or theme at the same time.

TERM	DEFINITION	EXAMPLE
Pathetic fallacy	Giving weather or nature human emotions that mirror the mood of a character or scene.	A storm during an argument; bright sunshine during a happy reunion.
Symbolic setting	A location that represents an idea bigger than itself.	An empty house representing loss; a garden in bloom representing hope.
Setting as mirror	Details of a setting reflecting a character's internal state without saying so directly.	A cluttered, dusty room suggesting a character's own neglected emotional state.
Setting as contrast	A setting that deliberately contrasts with the mood of a scene, creating irony.	A cheerful fairground description during a sad farewell.

Golden rule to copy down: whenever weather, light, or a physical space is described in unusual detail in a poem, always ask "does this setting detail mirror or contrast with how a character is feeling?" It is almost never just background information.

STRUCTURE 3 — THE SETTING-AS-MOOD METHOD

STRUCTURE 3 OF 6

Step-by-step for any setting question

1. Identify the specific setting detail (weather, light, season, room, object in the space).
2. Decide: does it MIRROR the mood (matches it) or CONTRAST with it (opposite, creating irony)?
3. Quote the exact phrase.
4. Explain the connection between the setting detail and the character's/speaker's emotional state.
5. Link to the poem's wider theme.

🔪 STRUCTURE 4 — PATHETIC FALLACY SPOTTER

STRUCTURE 4 OF 6

Distinguish pathetic fallacy from plain personification

- **Personification:** giving anything non-human a human quality, anywhere in the poem.
- **Pathetic fallacy:** specifically when NATURE OR WEATHER is given emotion that matches or reflects a character's mood or a scene's atmosphere.
- Every pathetic fallacy is a type of personification, but not every personification is pathetic fallacy — use the more specific term when weather/nature is involved, it shows stronger technical vocabulary.

🔪 STRUCTURE 5 — FIRST STANZA VS. FINAL STANZA SETTING COMPARISON

STRUCTURE 5 OF 6

A favourite GL exam angle — compare how setting is described at the start vs the end

1. Note the setting details given in the opening stanza.
2. Note the setting details given in the final stanza.
3. Has the setting itself changed, or has the way it's DESCRIBED changed (suggesting the character's perspective has shifted, not the place itself)?
4. Explain what this shift reveals about character development or theme.

🔪 STRUCTURE 6 — THE FULL CHARACTER/SETTING ANSWER FORMULA

STRUCTURE 6 OF 6

Use this exact structure for character AND setting questions

1. Identify the specific detail (character detail or setting detail).
2. Quote it exactly.
3. State clearly what it reveals or reflects (a personality trait, an emotional state, a mood).
4. Say whether this is direct or indirect characterisation/setting-as-mood, using the correct term (speaker/persona, pathetic fallacy, symbolic setting, etc.).
5. Link it to the theme of the whole poem.

PRACTICE EXTRACTS — APPLY THE METHODS NOW

"Grandad's coat still hangs by the door, sleeves slightly curled, as though still holding the shape of his arms."

What does this detail reveal, and how?

"The sky had turned the same grey as her mood, flat and unmoving, refusing to change."

Is this pathetic fallacy or plain personification? _____ Mirror or contrast?

"He said only, 'It's fine.' He said it twice. Then he said nothing else at all."

What does the repeated, then absent, speech suggest about this character's true feelings?
